



Park Güell

A hillside transformed into a colorful, exotic, and joyous garden for the people of Barcelona

In 1900, Catalan Modernist architect Antoni Gaudí (1852–1926) was commissioned by his friend and patron Eusebi Güell to design a self-contained suburb in the hills outside Barcelona. It was to contain 60 houses in a garden setting. Between 1900 and 1914, Gaudí built an extraordinary park filled with the symbolism of religion, Catalan nationalism, ancient myth, and even freemasonry.

Beauty from failure

Gaudí gave expression to his distinctive naturalist style and passion for color and organic forms, creating what he imagined

as a covered marketplace for residents from a forest of fluted columns. A sinuous, multicolored tiled stone bench snakes along the edge of the terrace. Gaudí undertook no leveling on the site, instead creating a network of roads carried by viaducts supported by pillars shaped like palm trees. He also installed an irrigation system that helped transform what was known as Muntanya Pelada (“bare mountain”) into a haven for wildlife.

By the time Güell died in 1926, it was clear the project was a commercial flop—only two houses had been built. Barcelona City Council eventually bought Park Güell in 1922, opening it to the public in 1926.

INSPIRED BY NATURE

The layout of the park illustrates Gaudí's belief that, since there are no absolutely straight lines in nature, there should be none in architecture. Roads and paths wind their way along the hillsides, zigzagging down to lower levels, creating a jellyfishlike pattern.

